

The Sensory Play Activity Card Deck

80 cards across 4 age bands (0–6m, 6–12m, 12–24m, 24–36m). Stuff you own. 5–20 minutes each. No Pinterest-perfect required.

Read this first (page 1)

Sensory play sounds like it should be a craft project. It isn't. It's the thing you do for 10 minutes between the third meltdown and the second snack, using a colander and a bowl of dried beans.

These cards are designed for:

- Real life, with one tired parent
- Stuff you almost certainly already own
- 5–20 minute attention spans, not “all afternoon” projects
- Babies who put everything in their mouths (every card flagged for choke-safe materials)
- Toddlers who get bored after 4 minutes
- Days you have 0 emotional energy to invent something

Pick one card from the kid's age band. Set it up. Walk away while they explore. Or sit with them — whichever you need today.

That's the entire system.

— Soothemade

This is a planning tool, not pediatric advice. Always supervise infants and toddlers during play. Adjust materials for your child's specific developmental stage and any allergies. When in doubt, call your pediatrician.

How to use this deck

1. **Print on cardstock.** Cut along the lines. 4 cards per US Letter page.
 2. **Sort by age band** (color-coded — sage olive 0–6m, terracotta 6–12m, wheat 12–24m, plum 24–36m).
 3. **Keep the current age band in a small basket.** Out of sight but accessible.
 4. **Pull one when needed.** Don't overthink. Read aloud to the kid if they're old enough.
 5. **Adapt freely.** No rice? Use beans. No paint? Use shaving cream. The point is texture + curiosity, not the specific item.
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A note on safety

For 0–6m and 6–12m cards: **anything that fits through a toilet-paper tube is a choking hazard.** Stay within arm's reach for all activities involving small items.

For 12+m: still supervise, but you can do “set up and step back” for many activities.

We've marked any cards that need extra-careful supervision with **▲ supervision.**

AGE BAND 1 — 0 TO 6 MONTHS (20 cards)

At this age, the work is in noticing. Babies absorb texture, sound, temperature, light. You don't need products. You need contrast.

Card 1.1 — High-Contrast Card Show

Time: 5–10 min · **▲ supervision** **Materials:** 3–5 black-and-white images on paper, or you can draw simple shapes with a marker on white paper

Sit baby in a bouncer or hold them. Hold each card about 8–12 inches from their face. Move it slowly side to side. Watch their eyes track. Switch cards every ~30 sec.

Why this works: Newborn vision focuses best at 8–12 inches with high contrast. Builds visual tracking.

Card 1.2 — Texture Trail on the Arm

Time: 5 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a soft cloth, a feather (or scarf), a wooden spoon, a metal spoon

Lay baby down. One by one, drag each item lightly down their arm or leg. Watch their face. Name the texture as you go. "Soft." "Cold." "Smooth."

Why this works: Skin is the largest sensory organ. Texture variation builds tactile awareness.

Card 1.3 — Mirror Play

Time: 5–15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** any mirror

Hold baby in front of a mirror. Wave their hand. Make faces. Sing. Move closer and further away. Babies start recognizing faces (including their own) around 4–5 months.

Why this works: Self-recognition. Plus mirrors are the cheapest, longest-lasting "toy" you'll ever own.

Card 1.4 — Crinkle Paper Hands

Time: 5 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** 2–3 sheets of crinkly paper (tissue paper, parchment, a clean grocery bag)

Place baby on their back. Hand them a sheet of crinkle paper. Let them grab, scrunch, and pull. The sound and texture combo is a huge hit.

Why this works: Auditory + tactile + grip strength. Cause-and-effect introduction.

Card 1.5 — Black-and-White Walk-Around

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** baby carrier or your arms

Walk slowly around the house, narrating what you see. Stop at one high-contrast object per room (a black picture frame on white wall, the dark TV against a bright shelf). Hold baby still for 30 sec at each. Name what they're looking at.

Why this works: Vision + language exposure + spatial awareness.

Card 1.6 — Texture Bin in a Bag

Time: 5 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a clear ziplock bag, hair gel + small objects (sequins, glitter, pom-poms, plastic letters)

Squeeze hair gel into a ziplock. Add small objects. Seal tight (tape edges for extra security). Lay flat in front of baby on the floor. They squish, slide, and explore safely without anything reaching their mouth.

Why this works: Tactile + visual + contained mess.

Card 1.7 — Slow Song Bath Time

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** the bath, your voice

Skip the bath toys. Sing slowly. Let baby feel the water moving on their skin. Pour water on different parts (back, tummy, toes) and watch their reaction. Talk through what you're doing.

Why this works: Tactile + temperature + auditory + parent-bond.

Card 1.8 — Tummy-Time Mirror

Time: 5–10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** mirror or shiny tray, blanket

Lay baby on tummy on a blanket. Place a small mirror (or a shiny baking tray) in front of them. They lift their head to look at "the other baby." Cheats the work of tummy time.

Why this works: Neck strength + self-recognition + tummy-time tolerance.

Card 1.9 — Slow Scarf Drag

Time: 5 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a lightweight silk scarf or muslin square

Hold baby in your lap. Drag the scarf slowly across their face, then over their hands. They'll grab. Pull gently — feel the resistance. Drape it on their head, then "peek-a-boo" lift it off.

Why this works: Tactile + early object permanence.

Card 1.10 — Sound Walk

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** baby carrier

Take baby on a slow indoor or outdoor walk. Stop at sounds. The fridge humming. A bird outside. The dryer. Name each. "That's the fridge. Hmm." Repeat the sound back to them.

Why this works: Auditory discrimination + language exposure.

Card 1.11 — Foot Discovery

Time: 5 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** different fabric textures (a sock, a knit blanket, a smooth sheet)

Lay baby on back. Rub their bare foot against each fabric. Wiggle their toes. Let them push against the fabric. Around 4 months they "discover" their feet — this card extends that.

Why this works: Tactile + body awareness.

Card 1.12 — Ice-Cube Hand Touch

Time: 5 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** one ice cube, a hand towel

Hold baby in your lap. Briefly touch the ice cube to the back of their hand. They'll jerk. Smile and say "cold!" Wipe the hand. Wait a few sec. Repeat once or twice. Don't overdo.

Why this works: Temperature awareness + cause-effect.

Card 1.13 — Soft-Box Garden

Time: 10–15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a shallow box or bin, several soft items (a knit ball, a felt square, a soft toy)

Place a few large, soft, choke-safe items in the box. Sit baby next to it. They reach. They pull. They squish. They drop. They reach again. Pure exploration.

Why this works: Reach + grasp + cause-effect.

Card 1.14 — Lullaby Floor Time

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a soft blanket, your voice or quiet music

Lay baby on a soft blanket on the floor. Lie next to them. Sing a slow lullaby. Move their arms and legs gently in time. Pause. Repeat. Or just be quiet together.

Why this works: Co-regulation + bonding + auditory.

Card 1.15 — Texture Tray (Choke-Safe)

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a tray, large items: a wooden spoon, a silicone teether, a soft brush, a large fabric scrap, a smooth stone (golf ball size minimum)

Lay tray in front of baby. They reach, grab, mouth. All items must be larger than a toilet-paper tube. Rotate items as they tire of each.

Why this works: Texture + grasp + oral exploration.

Card 1.16 — Bubble Watch

Time: 5–10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** bubble solution + wand (or DIY: dish soap + water)

Blow bubbles slowly above baby (don't pop on their face). Watch them track. Pop one with their hand. Around 4–6 months their eyes will follow consistently.

Why this works: Visual tracking + cause-effect.

Card 1.17 — Foil-Pan Sound Show

Time: 5 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a metal cookie sheet or foil pan, a wooden spoon

Sit baby in your lap. Tap the pan gently with the spoon at different spots. Vary the speed and force. Let them try (they'll just whack — that's fine).

Why this works: Auditory + cause-effect + arm motion.

Card 1.18 — Belly Massage

Time: 5 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a tiny bit of unscented baby oil (optional), warm hands

Rub small circles on baby's belly. Press gently. Stretch their arms across their chest. Cycle their legs. Talk to them throughout. Calm voice.

Why this works: Bonding + body awareness + can help with gas/digestion.

Card 1.19 — Cold Spoon Teether

Time: 5 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a clean metal spoon, the freezer

Pop a spoon in the freezer for 15 min. Hand to baby (around 4+ months when teething starts). They mouth the cold spoon. Soothing for sore gums.

Why this works: Cold + texture + teething relief.

Card 1.20 — Outside Blanket Time

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a blanket, the outdoors, shade

Lay blanket in a shaded outdoor spot (grass, patio). Place baby on it. Don't entertain. Let them watch leaves move, hear birds, feel air. You sit and breathe too.

Why this works: Sensory variety + co-regulation + you get sun.

AGE BAND 2 — 6 TO 12 MONTHS (20 cards)

Now they can sit, then crawl, then pull up. The work is in safe exploration of bigger spaces and new textures, including food-as-play.

Card 2.1 — Spoons in a Bowl

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a large mixing bowl, 5–6 wooden or metal spoons of different sizes

Sit baby on the floor. Place bowl with spoons. They dump. They pick up. They bang. They put spoons back in. Cheapest 10 minutes of magic you'll find.

Why this works: Grasp + dump + cause-effect.

Card 2.2 — Edible Sensory Bin (Cooked Pasta)

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** cooked pasta (cooled), a shallow tray

Cook pasta. Cool it. Spread on a tray. Baby touches, squishes, mouths. Drain water first — slippery wet pasta is a fall risk on tile floors.

Why this works: Texture + safe-to-mouth + fine motor.

Card 2.3 — Fabric Pull Box

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a tissue box or wipes box, several scarves or fabric scraps tied together

Stuff fabric strips through the slot of an empty box. Let baby pull them out one at a time. The “endless pull” is fascinating at this age.

Why this works: Pinch grip + cause-effect + fine motor.

Card 2.4 — Ice Cube Tray Find

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** silicone ice cube tray, 6–10 medium-size objects (NOT small enough to choke — keep large)

Place one object in each compartment. Baby explores. They pull out, examine, put back. Repeat with rotating objects.

Why this works: Hand-eye + sorting precursor + grip variety.

Card 2.5 — Pots-and-Pans Drum Circle

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** 2–3 pots, wooden spoons, a metal spoon

Sit on the kitchen floor. Tap each pot — different sounds. Hand baby the spoon. They bang. Loudly. Tolerate this.

Why this works: Auditory + arm motion + parent regulation training.

Card 2.6 — Water Pour Station

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a shallow tub or sink, 2 cups, a small sponge

Sit baby on the floor (towel underneath) or in a high chair pulled to a sink. Put a small amount of water + cups + sponge in a tub. They scoop, pour, squeeze. Wet but worth it.

Why this works: Cause-effect + fine motor + water love.

Card 2.7 — Tape on Hands

Time: 5–10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** masking tape or painter's tape

Stick small pieces of tape on baby's hands or feet. They try to remove them. Quiet, focused activity that builds problem-solving.

Why this works: Fine motor + problem-solving + focus.

Card 2.8 — Slow Crawl Obstacle Course

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** pillows, blankets, a small box

Build a "hill" of pillows. Drape a blanket as a tunnel. Place a small box at the end. Encourage baby to crawl through. They'll problem-solve their way.

Why this works: Gross motor + spatial + problem-solving.

Card 2.9 — Frozen Yogurt Painting

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** plain yogurt, 1 drop food coloring, a baking sheet

Spread yogurt on a sheet. Add a drop of color in one corner. Baby smears, eats, smears. Safe to mouth. Wash hands after.

Why this works: Edible art + texture + color exposure.

Card 2.10 — Texture Path Walk

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision (especially if mobile) Materials:** different rugs, a soft towel, a smooth tile floor, a yoga mat

Lay out 4–5 textures in a line. Help baby crawl or walk over each. They feel different surfaces underfoot. Name each.

Why this works: Tactile + proprioception + vocabulary.

Card 2.11 — Object Permanence Hide

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a small toy, a cloth or muslin square

Show baby the toy. Cover it with the cloth. Pause. Lift the cloth. "There it is!" Repeat. Around 8–10 months they start understanding hidden objects exist.

Why this works: Object permanence + memory + delight.

Card 2.12 — Tray of Snow (Real or Fake)

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a tray, real snow OR shaving cream OR whipped cream

Place a mound on a tray in front of baby in a high chair. They poke, smear, taste (if edible). Use whipped cream if you want it taste-safe.

Why this works: Texture + temperature (if real snow) + edible exploration.

Card 2.13 — Bell on a Stick

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a wooden spoon, a small jingle bell, ribbon

Tie a small bell (securely) to the end of a wooden spoon. Baby shakes it. Listens. Shakes again. Repeats.

Why this works: Auditory + cause-effect + grip.

Card 2.14 — Cardboard Box House

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** any cardboard box, scissors (parent), markers

Cut a window and door in a box. Place baby inside with a few toys. Peek in the window. Peek out. They love this.

Why this works: Spatial awareness + peekaboo + social.

Card 2.15 — Spaghetti Pull

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** cooked spaghetti, a colander

Place colander on a tray. Thread cooked (cooled) spaghetti through the holes. Baby pulls strands. Slippery, slimy, edible.

Why this works: Texture + pull + fine motor.

Card 2.16 — Light and Shadow Play

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a flashlight, a darker room

Shine a flashlight on the wall. Move it slowly. Make shapes with your hand. Baby tries to grab the light. Magic.

Why this works: Visual tracking + cause-effect (when they try to “catch” it).

Card 2.17 — Fingerprint Yogurt Art

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** yogurt + small dish + paper

Dip baby’s finger in yogurt. Press on paper. Make dots, lines. They’ll smear. Some prints will show. Save one.

Why this works: Fine motor + early creative expression + safe-to-mouth.

Card 2.18 — Tape Lines on the Floor

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** masking tape

Make a simple shape (a square, a road) with tape on the floor. Crawl along it. Drive cars on it. Encourage them to do the same.

Why this works: Visual-motor + early spatial reasoning.

Card 2.19 — Outdoor Container Dump

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a basket, leaves/sticks/pinecones (large, choke-safe)

Outside. Fill a basket with natural items. Help baby dump it. Refill. Dump. The repetition is the point.

Why this works: Gross motor + nature + cause-effect.

Card 2.20 — Soft Ball Roll

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a soft ball (any size larger than 3")

Sit a few feet from baby. Roll the ball to them. They grab. You ask for it back ("ball please"). Repeat. Early turn-taking.

Why this works: Gross motor + social reciprocity + early language.

AGE BAND 3 — 12 TO 24 MONTHS (20 cards)

They're walking, talking, beginning pretend play. The work is in messier, more independent exploration with longer attention spans.

Card 3.1 — Big Sensory Bin (Rice)

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** uncooked rice (~4 cups), a deep bin, cups + scoops + small toys

Dump rice in a bin. Add cups and a few buried toys. Toddler scoops, dumps, "finds." Some rice will end up on the floor. Vacuum after, not during.

Why this works: Tactile + sorting + fine motor.

Card 3.2 — Color Sorting Cups

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** 4 cups in different colors (or labeled), 20 small items (large pom-poms, blocks, soft balls)

Show toddler: pom-poms go in matching cups. Demonstrate one. Walk away. They'll sort some, mismatch some, dump some. All fine.

Why this works: Categorization + fine motor + color exposure.

Card 3.3 — Window Markers

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** dry-erase markers, a window, soapy water for cleanup

Toddler draws on a window. Yes really. Wipes off with water + cloth. The vertical surface is great for shoulder/arm strength.

Why this works: Gross motor + spatial + art.

Card 3.4 — Sticker Page

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** stickers (any), a piece of paper

Hand them stickers. Hand them paper. Walk away. They'll peel, stick, peel again. Peeling is half the activity.

Why this works: Fine motor + pincer grip + focus.

Card 3.5 — Bath Cup Pour

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** the bath, 4–5 cups of different sizes

In the bath: just cups. They pour from one to the other. Spill. Refill. Pour again. 20 minutes can disappear into this.

Why this works: Cause-effect + volume + fine motor.

Card 3.6 — Bowl + Spoon Sorting

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** 2 bowls, a spoon, ~30 small items (Cheerios, pasta, pom-poms)

Items in one bowl. Empty bowl next to it. They spoon items from one to the other. Some on the floor. Mostly in the bowl.

Why this works: Fine motor + spoon practice + sorting.

Card 3.7 — Felt Board Story

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a piece of felt (any color), small felt shapes (cut from craft felt — circles, squares, triangles, an animal silhouette)

Felt sticks to felt without glue. Toddler arranges shapes on the board. Tell a story with them. Or let them.

Why this works: Spatial + storytelling + fine motor.

Card 3.8 — Playdough Tools

Time: 25 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** playdough (store-bought or DIY: 2c flour, 1c salt, 1c water, 2 tbsp oil, 1 tbsp cream of tartar; cook 3 min until ball forms), rolling pin, plastic knife, cookie cutters

Hand them the works. They roll, cut, mash. Let them.

Why this works: Fine motor + grip + open-ended creative.

Card 3.9 — Bubble Wrap Stomp

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** bubble wrap, tape

Tape bubble wrap to the floor. Toddler stomps, jumps, sits, pops. They will love this irrationally.

Why this works: Gross motor + auditory + cause-effect.

Card 3.10 — Frozen Color Cubes

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** ice cube tray + water + food coloring, a baking sheet

The night before: fill a tray with water, add 1 drop of food coloring per cube. Freeze. Activity day: pop ice cubes onto a baking sheet. Toddler slides them around, watches them melt, sees color spread.

Why this works: Temperature + color mixing + observation.

Card 3.11 — Threading Pasta

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** uncooked penne or rigatoni, pipe cleaners (cut to 6" lengths)

Toddler threads pasta onto pipe cleaners. Hard at first, gets satisfying. Make "necklaces" they can wear.

Why this works: Fine motor + bilateral coordination + pride product.

Card 3.12 — Big Cardboard Painting

Time: 25 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a large cardboard box (flattened) or roll of paper, washable paint, brushes, painter's tape

Tape cardboard to the floor or wall. Toddler paints. Big strokes. Use shower-able paint. End in a bath.

Why this works: Gross motor + color + arm range.

Card 3.13 — Mystery Bag

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a fabric bag, 5 random household objects (spoon, sock, banana, brush, plastic toy)

Put objects in a bag. Toddler reaches in, feels (without looking), guesses. Pull it out and check.

Why this works: Tactile discrimination + vocabulary + memory.

Card 3.14 — Salt Tray Writing

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a baking tray, ~1 cup salt (or sand)

Spread a thin layer of salt on the tray. Toddler draws with their finger. Erase by tipping. Repeat. Pre-writing skill.

Why this works: Pre-writing + fine motor + tactile.

Card 3.15 — Animal Walks

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** none

Call out an animal: "elephant!" Stomp like an elephant. "Bunny!" Hop. "Snake!" Crawl. Toddler copies.

Why this works: Gross motor + imitation + body awareness.

Card 3.16 — Pour-and-Drink Tea Party

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** small pitcher, small cups, a small amount of juice or water

Set up a tiny tea party. Toddler pours from pitcher to cups. Some spills. They serve you. Drink whatever they pour. (Sip water.)

Why this works: Fine motor + practical life + roleplay.

Card 3.17 — Magnetic Letters on Fridge

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** magnetic letters, the fridge

Stick letters on fridge at toddler height. They take them off, put them back, dump them. Name the letters as they pick them up.

Why this works: Fine motor + early letter exposure + vertical surface work.

Card 3.18 — Frozen Berry Sensory Cup

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision** **Materials:** a few frozen blueberries (or any small frozen fruit), a small clear cup, water

Put frozen berries in a cup. Add room-temp water. They watch the berries move, the water cool, condensation form. They taste.

Why this works: Observation + temperature + sensory.

Card 3.19 — Tape “Cars Garage”

Time: 25 min · **▲ supervision** **Materials:** masking tape, toy cars

Tape parking spots on the floor (label them A, B, C). Toddler “parks” cars. Moves them. Makes new garages.

Why this works: Spatial + roleplay + organization.

Card 3.20 — Outside Mud Kitchen

Time: 30 min · **▲ supervision** **Materials:** old kitchen pots, a few wooden spoons, dirt, water

Outside, in old clothes. Set up a “mud kitchen.” Toddler stirs mud “soup,” serves it, makes “pies.” Hose down after.

Why this works: Open-ended pretend + nature + sensory.

AGE BAND 4 — 24 TO 36 MONTHS (20 cards)

Pretend play, language explosion, real fine motor. Cards lean toward roleplay, problem-solving, and longer focus.

Card 4.1 — Pretend Vet Clinic

Time: 25 min · **▲ supervision** **Materials:** stuffed animals, bandages or paper towel strips, a notebook + crayon

Set up a “vet clinic.” Toddler is the vet. Each stuffed animal comes in with a “problem.” They diagnose, treat, wrap a bandage. Make a chart.

Why this works: Roleplay + empathy + fine motor.

Card 4.2 — Color-by-Number Lite

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision** **Materials:** a simple line drawing with sections labeled 1, 2, 3, crayons, a key (1=red, 2=blue, 3=green)

Print or draw. Show them the key. They color each section the matching color. Beginner version: only 3–4 sections, 3–4 colors.

Why this works: Matching + focus + fine motor.

Card 4.3 — Build-a-Track Lego

Time: 30 min · **▲ supervision** **Materials:** Legos (Duplo for younger end), a small ball or marble (large enough not to choke)

Build a track for a ball to roll along. Add slopes, turns, a “tunnel.” Test it. Rebuild when it fails.

Why this works: Spatial + problem-solving + cause-effect.

Card 4.4 — Salad Spinner Painting

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a salad spinner, paper cut to fit, washable paint

Cut paper to fit inside the spinner. Drop a few blobs of paint. Spin. Lift the lid. Repeat with new paper, new colors.

Why this works: Cause-effect + delight + abstract art.

Card 4.5 — Cooking Helper: Real Recipe

Time: 30 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a simple no-bake recipe (e.g., yogurt + granola + fruit “parfaits”)

Toddler helps assemble. They pour, sprinkle, layer. They eat the result.

Why this works: Practical life + measuring + pride.

Card 4.6 — Treasure Hunt with Clues

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** 4–5 picture clues, a small “treasure”

Draw simple picture clues that lead to objects around the house. Each clue leads to the next location. The last has the treasure (a sticker, a snack, a small toy).

Why this works: Sequencing + problem-solving + memory.

Card 4.7 — Stamp Garden

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** sliced fruits/veggies (apple, potato, celery), washable paint, paper

Dip the cut side of each fruit/veg into paint. Press on paper. Make a garden, a city, abstract patterns. Different shapes for each.

Why this works: Texture + cause-effect + art.

Card 4.8 — Pretend Grocery Store

Time: 25 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** kitchen pantry items, a basket, paper “money,” a small register or notepad

Set up a “store.” Toddler is the cashier. You “shop” with the basket and pay. Switch roles.

Why this works: Roleplay + counting + social.

Card 4.9 — Big-Paper Body Trace

Time: 30 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a large roll of paper (or taped-together sheets), markers

Have them lie on the paper. Trace their body. They color it in — face, clothes, shoes. Stand it up on a wall.

Why this works: Body awareness + identity + scale.

Card 4.10 — DIY Sticker Sorting

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** ~30 stickers in 3 types (animals, shapes, foods), 3 sheets of paper

Sort stickers by category, each on its own page. Then they stick them down.

Why this works: Categorization + fine motor + early classification.

Card 4.11 — Magic Disappearing Pictures

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** white paper, a white crayon, watercolor paint, brush

Draw a hidden picture with the white crayon (invisible on white paper). Hand to toddler with watercolor. They paint over it — the picture “appears.”

Why this works: Surprise + cause-effect + magic.

Card 4.12 — Story Stones

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** 5–10 smooth stones, paint pens

Paint a simple picture on each stone (a sun, a bird, a heart, a tree). Once dry: toddler picks 3 stones at random and tells a story using them.

Why this works: Narrative + imagination + memory.

Card 4.13 — Mini Garden Planting

Time: 30 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a pot, soil, fast-growing seeds (basil, sunflower, beans)

Plant seeds together. Talk about water, sun, time. Check daily. Eat when ready (if applicable).

Why this works: Patience + nature + responsibility.

Card 4.14 — Doll/Stuffed-Animal Bath

Time: 25 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** plastic doll or non-precious stuffed animal, mild soap, a tub of warm water, towel

Toddler bathes the doll. Practice gentle, careful. Dry it after.

Why this works: Practical life + empathy + caretaking.

Card 4.15 — Frozen Treasure Hunt

Time: 25 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** small plastic toys, a freezable container, water

The night before: freeze a few small toys in a block of water. Activity day: toddler “rescues” the frozen toys using warm water in a cup and a wooden spoon.

Why this works: Problem-solving + cause-effect + patience.

Card 4.16 — Sound Story

Time: 20 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** wooden spoon + pot, paper, a rain stick (or rice in a bottle)

Tell a short story. When you say a key word, toddler makes a matching sound. “The rain started...” rice bottle. “The thunder rolled...” pot drum.

Why this works: Auditory + narrative + participation.

Card 4.17 — Mini Construction Site

Time: 30 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a sensory bin with dried beans or rice, toy trucks/ diggers, small “rocks” (large beads or pom-poms)

Trucks scoop and dump in the bin. Build “piles” and “roads.” Real construction-site narrative.

Why this works: Pretend + fine motor + open-ended.

Card 4.18 — Pretend Phone Calls

Time: 10 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** two old phones or banana phones

Pretend to call grandma. Pretend to order pizza. Pretend to call a friend. Practice conversation flow.

Why this works: Language + roleplay + turn-taking.

Card 4.19 — Color Hunt Around the House

Time: 15 min · **▲ supervision Materials:** a small bag, the house

Pick a color. Toddler hunts for 5 things in that color. Put them in the bag. Switch colors.

Why this works: Color recognition + scanning + categorization.

Card 4.20 — Family Picture Story

Time: 25 min · **▲ supervision** **Materials:** family photos (printed or on phone), paper, crayons

Look at a family photo together. Toddler draws something from the picture. Tells a story about it. Save the drawing.

Why this works: Memory + narrative + family connection.

TROUBLESHOOTING

“They lost interest in 3 minutes.”

Normal. Try a different card. Or repeat the same card in 2 hours — short attention re-engages with novelty after a break.

“They keep eating the materials.”

If under 12 months, use only edible materials (cooked pasta, yogurt, whipped cream, frozen fruit). After 12 months, demonstrate “no eating” and stay close. Choose differently next time.

“They make a huge mess.”

Yes. That’s the cost. Tactical responses: - Pre-layout: high chair tray, vinyl tablecloth on the floor, the bath as a “containment vessel” - Outside whenever weather allows - Lower your standards for the next 20 minutes

“I have multiple kids of different ages.”

The older kid can lead with the younger one. Sensory play is one of the few activities where mixed-age works well. Just supervise the safety differential.

“I don’t have time to prep.”

Use only Cards labeled 5–10 min. Most of those need nothing more than items already in your kitchen.

A note about progress

You don't need to track which cards you've done. You don't need to do them in order. You don't need to "complete the deck."

If a card works, run it again next week. If a kid loves one specific card, do it 6 times in 2 weeks — that's how toddlers learn.

The deck is here to give you options when your brain runs out. It's a basket of "yeses" so you don't have to be the no.

— Soothemade

This is a planning tool. Supervision is required for all activities. Adapt materials for your child's developmental stage and any food allergies. When in doubt, ask your pediatrician.